

GENEROUS LIVING

“Unlocking the Rewards of Generosity”

The Bible has much to say about money:

- There are 500 Scriptures in the Bible concerning prayer...
- There are 500 verses concerning faith...
- There are more than 2,000 Scriptures concerning money and possessions...
- Jesus talked about money in 16 of His 38 parables...

Money is a test from God. It is a priority test! Are we passing or failing? (Be honest with yourself)

The principle of first fruit was established in the Old Testament book of Exodus. Exodus 13:2,12,13 (NLT) ***“Dedicate to me all the firstborn sons of Israel and every firstborn***

male animal. They are mine.” 12 All firstborn sons and firstborn male animals must be presented to the LORD. 13 A firstborn male donkey may be redeemed from the LORD by presenting a lamb in its place. But if you decide not to make the exchange, the donkey must be killed by breaking its neck. However, you must redeem every firstborn son.”

God declared the firstborn belonged to Him 16 times in Scripture!

It is interesting to note that God required the firstborn. He did not say to allow the ewe to bear nine lambs and then give number ten to Him. It is possible to be a tither without adhering to the principle of first fruit. First fruit is giving Him a minimum of 10% BEFORE we access any of the 100%!

It doesn't take faith to give one out of ten, but it requires great faith to give the first of ten!

Have you ever wondered why God respected Abel's offering but rejected Cain's? Genesis 4:3-5 (KJV) "***And in process of time it came to pass, that Cain brought of the fruit of the ground an offering unto the LORD. 4 And Abel, he also brought of the firstlings of his flock and of the fat thereof. And the LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering: 5 But unto Cain and to his offering he had not respect. And Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell.***" Abel brought the firstborn; Cain brought his offering in the process of time. When he decided to. When he got around to it!

What we give to God is never lost because He redeems it for us, but what we withhold from him will always be lost. The reason for the loss is that our possessions no longer have the redemptive power of God working for them.

Matthew 16:25 (NLT) ***“If you try to keep your life for yourself, you will lose it. But if you give up your life for me, you will find true life.”***

What are we to do with the first fruit? Proverbs 3:9-10 (NKJV) ***“Honor the LORD with your possessions, And with the first-fruits of all your increase; 10 So your barns will be filled with plenty, And your vats will overflow with new wine.”*** These verses point out the following principles:

- Tithing is a priority of God... ***“Honor the Lord with your possessions...”***
- The first fruit is required... Honor him, ***“... With the first fruits of your increase...”***
- We will experience Gods provision... ***“Your barns will be filled with plenty...”***
- We can expect Him to bless us in a spiritual sense... ***“Your vats will overflow with new wine...”***

(Give 10 envelopes away – Give to Toi – One with 10 \$1 bills – One with 10 \$5 bills – One with 10 \$10 bills – One with 10 \$20 bills – One with 10 \$50 bills – One with 10 \$100 bills) The reason I went from \$1 to \$5 to \$10 to \$20 to \$50 to \$100 is because she proved to me as we went, that she was obedient and could be trusted!

Tithing the first Fruit is about:

- Obedience
- Trust

Why do I believe in tithing the First Fruit?

- 1) I believe the Word commands it.
- 2) Because I want to be obedient.
- 3) It proves I trust God.
- 4) It is a constant reminder to me who is my source.
- 5) It creates margins in my life that allow God to do more for me than before.

- 6) It connects the resources I possess to a Kingdom purpose.
- 7) It gives my job (Career) eternal significance. (I am no longer JUST a butler, baker, or candlestick maker)
- 8) It transforms my money into seed. (If it won't meet your need, make it your seed)
- 9) It kills the green giant, called greed.
- 10) It gives me the opportunity to invest into something that will survive me. (Think of all the people who have tithed in this church who have never met you or your family – They are slumbering in a grave but their gift is continuing to work for the Kingdom)

Just as the firstborn and first fruit belong to God, the tithe belongs to Him as well. Leviticus 27:30 (NKJV) “***And all the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the tree, is the LORD's. It is holy to the LORD.***”

CONCLUSION:

Some will say that tithing is a principle of the Law, but tithing:

- Predates the Law by 400 years...
- Became a part of the Law...
- Postdates the Law...

Listen to the words of Jesus: Matthew 23:23 (NLT) ***“How terrible it will be for you teachers of religious law and you Pharisees.***

Hypocrites! For you are careful to tithe even the tiniest part of your income, but you ignore the important things of the law—justice, mercy, and faith. You should tithe, yes, but you should not leave undone the more important things.”

Many blessings are promised to those who become tithers, but the first fruit offering is the trigger on the blessing. I hope you will pull the trigger today!

The following principles should be followed when engaging in tithing the first fruit:

- The tithe of first fruit is 10% of total family income...
- The tithe of first fruit belongs in the local church...
- The tithe of first fruit should never be directed or earmarked...
- The tithe of first fruit should be in God's house before one dime of the income is spent...

GENEROUS LIVING – UNLOCKING THE REWARDS OF GENEROSITY *LEARNING TO LIVE IN ABUNDANCE*

TEXT: John 10:10 (NKJV) *“The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.”*

INTRO: The word *“abundantly”* is defined by the Miriam Webster dictionary as *“existing or occurring in large amounts.”* I like that. Based on this definition the word *“abundantly”* is a great word! However, let’s look at this word in the original Greek context. The transliteration of the word *“abundantly”* is *“perissos”* (Per-is-sos) and means *“Over and above – Exceeding the number, measure, rank or need - More than is necessary – An advantage that causes one to exceed above measure.”* Who among us would like to live the abundant life?

I am convinced that when we get our attitude right in the giving department, we set ourselves up to be blessed in so many ways that it would deplete the space on my hard drive to tell you how many avenues of blessing the lord could choose while blessing us.

Today I want to explore three keys to abundance:

- The key of giving...
- The key of multiplication...
- The key of breaking the spirit of mammon...

I. THE KEY OF GIVING...

I choose to believe that everyone in my audience today would prefer to live in abundance rather than live with lack in our lives. I have tried poverty and I have tried a little bit of prosperity and my personal preference is prosperity.

The first key to abundance is giving. I should probably hasten on to say that the key to giving is more about attitude than about ability. We cannot talk about giving without talking about stewardship. We are stewards for God; we are his business managers; everything we have belongs to the Lord. When we realize who owns it all it is not nearly as difficult to follow His will in giving. If I give it all away at His direction, it is alright because there is more where that came from. (Larissa -She had \$20 but needed two one dollar bills)

I am Gods steward. What I have belongs to Him. He can direct it as He pleases. When He asks for it all I must remember *“It’s OK Dad, there’s more where that came from.”*

We should act like stewards rather than owners! Having the attitude of an owner, rather than a steward points to a conflict between who everything belongs to!

Tithing and giving is the defining test of all would-be-stewards. This is also the only area in which we are admonished to test God. Malachi 3:10 (NKJV) ***“Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this,” Says the LORD of hosts, “If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it.”***

Tithing is not a grim duty to be performed by the Christian. It is not a dry religious exercise which kills the Spirit of a service. It is not punishment intended to cost the believer hard earned cash. It is a wonderful opportunity to invest in the kingdom of God and in doing so; it brings unbelievable benefits to the tither not to mention protection from the devourer.

The first key to abundance is without question, tithing! If we cannot pass the tithing test with a good attitude, we can forget being in possession

of any of the other keys. It is really this simple; if we tithe with a good attitude we are blessed; if we do not tithe with a good attitude we are cursed.

II. KEY OF MULTIPLICATION...

Have we ever wanted or felt that we needed to multiply something?

- Multiply ourselves to get all our work done?
- Multiply the hours in a day?
- Multiply money to pay our bills?

Webster defines multiplication in the following way: *“A method used to find the result of adding a specified quantity repeatedly a specific number of times.”*

The Bible is full of instances of the miracle of multiplication:

- The strength of Israelite soldiers was multiplied on many occasions when they were hopelessly outnumbered...
- The meal and oil of the widow and her son was multiplied...
- The multiplication of a little boy's lunch...

There are at least two components to utilizing the key of multiplication.

- 1) The first key: A thing must be blessed before it can multiply! Jesus blessed the fish and bread before he distributed it to the multitudes. If we desire to use the key of multiplication in our finances we must first bless them. How do we bless them? Pray over them dedicating the first fruit to God, then following through to complete our part of the covenant. There are many sweet well-intentioned Christians who have never personally witnessed the miracle of multiplication where their

resources are concerned. It is not that they are bad people; they have just never understood the principle of blessing the first fruit before giving it to the Lord. Remember, we cannot give our tithe, it never belonged to us, we can only return it or steal it! When we dedicate our first fruit to Him, it makes the rest of our finances Holy! Then the remainder of our finances are made Holy and available for the miracle of multiplication!

- 2) The second component of the key of multiplication is as simple as the first. Only what is given away can multiply! The disciples were handling blessed bread which now had the power of multiplication on it! It had been blessed, so it had the potential for multiplication! If the disciples had decided to eat the meal themselves, it would not have been enough for twelve people, but when they started to give it away, they witnessed the miracle of multiplication. Even though the food was

blessed it had to be given away for it to multiply.

I am here to remind us today that only what we give away can be multiplied! If we need a financial blessing, we must find a way to sow a financial seed!

Giving above our tithe is turning the key in the lock of multiplication.

III. THE KEY OF BREAKING THE SPIRIT OF MAMMON...

Mammon is not really a word we go around using everyday but Jesus used this word in Matthew 6:24 (NKJV) ***“No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or else he will be loyal to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and mammon.”*** The fact that Jesus so clearly states that it is just as possible to serve mammon as it is to serve God, and even states that no one can serve both mammon and God at the same time, suggests to me that He is clearly

defining mammon as an idol which people worship, serve, and bow down to.

Mammon is an Aramaic word that essentially means riches. Jesus draws a striking contrast between the spirit of mammon and the spirit of God. He is saying that they are so diametrically opposed that it is not possible to serve both at once. Look at what Jesus say's:

- No one can serve two masters...
- He will hate one and love the other...
- He will be loyal to one and despise the other...

There is no middle of the road here; no half-in-half; no neutrality; no fence straddling will be permitted on this subject. The spirit of mammon is founded on pride and arrogance. The attitude of the spirit of mammon is:

- Man does not need God...
- Man is a little god himself...

- Man is self-sufficient...
- Man should trust in his own riches...

In the spiritual sense mammon is a spirit which trusts in riches. If we become seduced by the spirit of mammon our security is judged by the size of my bank account rather than what we have done to expand the Kingdom of God.

Money which is devoted to God and His purposes rather than trying to replace Him, acknowledges that it must be blessed by God, so that it can accomplish its maximum potential.

Money which has not been submitted to God has the spirit of mammon on it by default. To not pay our tithes is an automatic invitation for the spirit of mammon to rule over our finances and our lives. The spirit of mammon:

- Makes an attempt to buy happiness...
Things cannot satisfy...

- Attempts to control others with the almighty dollar... Always paying the check then causing others to feel as if they are in debt...
- Attempts to manipulate others by proving I am more prosperous than you... Because of my things I should be listened to...
- Makes a person believe they are a self-made man... Everything we have comes from, and belongs to God...

The spirit of mammon is looking for servants!
It is seeking worshippers! It will promise us
everything in the world but deliver emptiness!

When we think about it, mammon is nothing
more than the system of this fallen world that
stands in sharp opposition to God and his ways:

- Mammon say's to buy and sell; God say's to sow and reap...
- Mammon say's to take; God say's to give...

- Mammon say's to cheat and steal; God say's to give and receive...
- Mammon is selfish; God is generous...
- Mammon say's to hoard everything you can; God say's to give it away cheerfully...

CONCLUSION:

Before I leave the subject of mammon, I want to point out one more scripture. Luke 16:11-12 (NLT) *“And if you are untrustworthy about worldly wealth, who will trust you with the true riches of heaven? 12 And if you are not faithful with other people’s money, why should you be trusted with money of your own?”*

Some people would look at our subject today and say, this does not affect me; I don't have enough money to worry about it. It does not matter how much money we have, what matters is whose it is! If all we have belongs to God, then it is His money, not ours! If all that I have

belongs to God, then each new day brings a new test of stewardship! Will my resources have the spirit of God resting on them or will they be directed by the spirit of mammon?

We must prove ourselves faithful with a little before we will be given more! If we have little to nothing, we are a perfect candidate for the blessing of God because if we will prove to Him we can be faithful with a little, He will entrust us with much more! A person who is unjust with a little will be unjust with a whole lot more! Christians who cheat with a little will not become faithful when they are rich!

Do you want to live in abundance or in lack?